I struggled to comprehend the police's assertion that there might be grenade threats, jeopardizing our safety. Yet, I pondered, wasn't it more crucial there than anywhere else to traverse the wounded land and sow the seeds of love and hope along the way? My heart fervently questioned this, steadfast in the belief that these seeds would one day blossom into flowers of peace in the scarred terrain of Kashmir. This man, Rahul, had traversed on foot from Kanyakumari to Kashmir precisely to instil such faith and love. Despite numerous attempts to halt the march, he refused to yield. The march pressed on the following day, with a surge of people breaking through security barricades to draw closer to him. Everywhere, there was an inundation of love and the glow of hope.

He was love personified. As I observed, a sense of trepidation lingered, watching him embrace a fearless compassion and grace, reaching out to all who sought him. Yet, our concern for his and Priyanka's safety weighed on us heavily. In that moment, it dawned upon me that there was something more than just love and compassion actively guiding him. The nature of this force eluded my understanding. The Tricolour, our national flag, entrusted to his safekeeping in Kanyakumari, was unfurled proudly at Lal Chowk. In that moment, the trials and tribulations we had endured seemed to dissipate into the background. A profound joy and celebration overcame us, shared collectively. Despite the stringent security measures, the streets themselves were alive with festivity, and Kashmir joined us in rapture.

The following morning a miraculous event unfolded—snowfall in Kashmir during the rally. The landscape transformed into a poetic spectacle, a white paradise where the snow adorned everything. As Rahul commenced his speech, expectations of a triumphant celebration for this historic event were palpable. However, he unexpectedly delved into the narrative of his blood-stained, painful encounters with violence, delivering his words in a soft voice. A stunned silence enveloped the crowd. Standing among a group of women, we instinctively embraced Priyanka, who was nearby. Tears streamed down our faces as the profound gravity of the moment permeated our consciousness.